are not equally convincing. Nevertheless, despite these social changes, the right to abortion has been vigorously defended, and now comes to represent a sort of symbol of personal and bodily freedom and inviolability – a privacy issue. Such an approach has created a considerable obstacle to a more rational debate on the negative consequences of abortion on demand or on the very broad social grounds for it. We thus continue to see emotionally charged reactions to any suggestion to reduce the incidence of abortion (either by lowering the upper time limit, narrowing the grounds or by introducing social services aimed at reducing the demand for an abortion) or even attempts to discuss its ethical aspects. On the other hand, rushing through the chambers pieces of bills that dramatically restrict abortion rights, as done in Poland, is not helpful either, because it is seen – rightly or wrongly – as an imposition of the masculine conservative will over the freedom of women, all the more so under a socially conservative government.

Issues other than abortion are of even greater concern and fuel polarisation and populism. The same socially conservative stratum of society (in Eastern Europe and elsewhere) is also worried about what they perceive as a weakened European identity, Europe's failure to integrate migrants, in particular from Muslim countries, lack of interest in the persecution of Christians in the Middle East, about the marginalisation and vilifying of Christians in the West, as well as about efforts to codify gender theory and euthanasia. Many feel that we are witnessing a deliberate, ideologically driven campaign against traditional/Christian values, a true culture war being waged against what is now a Christian minority within European society. Little has been done to change that impression or to appease these fears or to enter into dialogue with them.

Within the geopolitical context, this culture war gets a further religious and international dimension, involving Catholics and Orthodox Christians. At least until the Russian invasion of Ukraine, there were many in Orthodox Eastern Europe and some among the more conservative Catholics in Central Europe that found Putin's call for a return to traditional values appealing. (Some continue to do so, despite the war in Ukraine.) Interestingly enough, even Pope Francis, whom many of the very same conservative Catholics would consider heretically progressive, agreed with Patriarch Kirill of Russia on a Joint Declaration in 2016, which among others expresses